

Jamaica



First a Spanish possession and then a British colony, the island of Jamaica won its independence in 1962.

1494 Columbus lands at Dry Harbour, now Discovery Bay, on his second voyage.

1509 Columbus's son Diego Colón takes the island and appoints Juan de Esquivel as the first governor.

1655 An English expedition under Admiral Penn lands. Spain capitulates. Island becomes haven for buccaneers. Sugar cane, cotton, and cattle are established in a slave-labor economy.

1660 The Spanish are finally expelled.

1670 Jamaica is formally ceded to England.

1820s Jamaica becomes one of the world's leading sugar-exporting nations.

1866 Jamaica becomes a British colony.

1938 Norman Manley forms the People's National Party (PNP) as a democratic socialist party. The PNP is the oldest political party in the English-speaking Caribbean.

1942 The discovery of bauxite and its subsequent development displaces sugar as the main industry.

1958–61 Jamaica forms part of the West Indies Federation.

1959 Internal self-government begins.

1962 Independence under the Jamaica Labour Party (JLP), a moderately conservative party, led by Alexander Bustamante.

1972 PNP elected under Michael Manley, its founder's son; reforms fail and street violence begins.

1980 Unpopular IMF austerity measures lead to JLP election win under Edward Seaga.

1989 PNP returned under Michael Manley; austerity continues.



Portia Simpson-Miller

Prime minister of Jamaica since 2006, Portia Simpson-Miller is the third female head of government in the anglophone Caribbean.

1992 Percival Patterson becomes prime minister upon Michael Manley's retirement.

1999 Violent protests over fuel tax increases.

2006 Portia Simpson-Miller of the PNP becomes first female prime minister.

«280–81 The Slave Trade

Haiti



A chronically poor nation occupying the western third of the island of Hispaniola.

1492 During his first voyage to the Americas, Columbus reaches Hispaniola.

1697 The buccaneer-based French community of Saint-Domingue is recognized by Spain under the Treaty of Ryswick and flourishes as a rich French plantation colony, with an estimated 500,000 slaves by 1789.

1791 A massacre of French by slaves signals the beginning of a bitter 13-year civil war under Haitian leader Toussaint L'Ouverture. The Haitians strongly resist French, Dutch, and English troops.

1804 Jean-Jacques Dessalines proclaims the independence of Haiti as the first black republic in the Americas and subsequently appoints himself emperor.

1806 Henri Christophe takes part in plot to overthrow Dessalines and is appointed president in 1807, becoming King Henri I in 1811 until his suicide in 1829.

1822–44 Haitians invade the neighboring Spanish colony of Santo Domingo and rule repressively.

1915–34 US occupation.

1957–71 François "Papa Doc" Duvalier's brutal dictatorship.

1971–86 Duvalier's son Jean-Claude, "Baby Doc," rules until forced to flee.

1990 Jean-Bertrand Aristide of left-wing Lavalas party elected; exiled in 1991 coup.

1994–95 US forces oust military. Aristide reinstated; new elections held.

1996 René Préval is elected president.

2000–04 Aristide returns as president, but is ousted by members of the military.

2006 New elections result in the former president René Préval taking office.

2008 Widespread food rioting caused by price increases leads to the fall of Prime Minister Alexis's government.

2009 World Bank and IMF cancel 80 percent of Haiti's debt.

2010 Magnitude 7.0 earthquake near Port-au-Prince kills around 300,000 people.

«228–29 Columbus Lands in the Caribbean
«280–81 The Slave Trade

Dominican Rep



Sharing the island of Hispaniola with Haiti, this was the first place to be settled by the Spanish.

1492 Columbus reaches the island of Hispaniola. The first area actually to be settled by Spaniards, it becomes the center of Spanish activity and rule in the region, producing gold, sugar, and finally cattle.

1697 The island is divided between Spain and France.

1795 French domination is extended to the Spanish section of Hispaniola, but this is occupied by native Haitian forces under Toussaint L'Ouverture. Between 1809 and 1844 French troops are ejected.

1844 The Dominican Republic achieves independence with the formal but arbitrary division of the two parts of the island.

1861 Spanish colonial rule is reestablished at the request of President Pedro Santana as a bulwark against Haitian attempts to take back the Dominican Republic.

1865 The country finally becomes independent from Spain but further years of instability ensue.

1916–24 The Dominican Republic is occupied by US troops; the US retains customs control until 1940.

1930 General Rafael Trujillo is elected president and establishes a brutal and repressive dictatorship, dominating political life directly or indirectly until his assassination in 1961.

1965 Civil war. US intervention.

1966 Pro-American Joaquín Balaguer starts the first of seven presidential terms over the next 30 years.

1996 Lionel Fernández of the moderate Dominican Liberation Party (PLD) succeeds Balaguer and pledges reforms to stamp out corruption.

1998 Major hurricane damage.

2000 Hipolito Mejía of the center-left Dominican Revolutionary Party (PRD) wins the presidency, but his popularity is soon eroded by high inflation, electricity shortages, and major bank collapses.

2004 Fernández is reelected and introduces austerity measures to stabilize the economy and reduce inflation.

«228–29 Columbus Lands in the Caribbean
«280–81 The Slave Trade

Bahamas



An English-speaking archipelago in the Atlantic, with a strong economy based on tourism.

1492 Columbus first sets foot on San Salvador (possibly Watling Island).

1647 Islands settled by Puritan refugees from Bermuda.

1690 The islands are granted by the British to the owners of Carolina.

1717 The British Crown assumes direct control, and the first British governor arrives the following year.

1781 Spain seizes the islands.

1783 The islands are recaptured by the British and confirmed as British territory.

1920–33 US prohibition laws turn Bahamas into bootlegging center.

1959–62 Introduction of male suffrage; women gain the vote.

1973 Independence from Britain.

1983 Narcotic-smuggling scandals involving the government.

1992 Free National Movement takes power, ending 25 years of Progressive Liberal Party (PLP) rule.

2002 PLP returns to power under Perry Christie.

2007 Free National Movement under Hubert Ingraham takes power.

«228–29 Columbus Lands in the Caribbean

Antigua & Barbuda



British influence remains strong in this former colony in the middle of the Leeward Islands.

1632 After settlement by the Spanish and French in the 16th and early 17th centuries, a permanent British settlement is established under Sir Thomas Warner.

1667 After a brief interlude of French occupation, the Treaty of Breda returns Antigua to Britain.

1860 Barbuda, hitherto owned by the British Codrington family, is formally incorporated into the colony

1951 Universal adult suffrage introduced.

1981 Independence from Britain under Vere Bird; union with Antigua opposed by the Barbudan secessionist movement.

1983 Islands support US invasion of Grenada.